

My no-scam pledge

Advisory from D.G. Messerschmitt May 2026

I will keep in mind that any voice, video, text, email, or web page may be a **fake**, even when it **appears** to originate from a trusted individual or organization. I won't even trust a recognizable voice on the phone.

I will always ask "am I in control here?"

- I am **not** in control if I **act** on an **unexpected** and **unsolicited** call, text, or email.
- I am in control if I **initiate** a deliberate and purposeful interaction based on information I found **independently from a reliable source** (and **not** a Google ad).

If not in control (especially if there are red flags like **urgency**, **anxiety**, **demand for money**, or a request for **confidential information**):

- I will **hang up** or **disengage** immediately!
- If in doubt, I will **regain control** by starting from scratch with contact information obtained **independently**.

I will never share **sensitive information** (SS number, password, credit card number, bank account number) by phone, email, or text.

I will avoid phone imposters by establishing a family **safeword**. I will lock my cell phone account using a **PIN**. I will avoid **paper checks**. I will set up **two-factor authentication** on email, online banking, and e-commerce accounts.

Tips from the “Better Business Bureau Scamtracker”

There is a wealth of information here:

<https://www.bbb.org/scamtracker/>

1. Never send money via gift card or wire transfer to someone you have never met face-to-face.
2. Avoid clicking on links or opening attachments or calling phone numbers in unsolicited emails.
3. Don't believe anything you see or hear online without independent checking, no matter how genuine it appears.
4. Double-check that your online purchase is secure (https:// URL) before checking out.
5. Use extreme caution when dealing with anyone you've met online.
6. Never share personally identifiable information with someone who has contacted you unsolicited, whether it's over the phone, by text or email, or on social media.
7. Resist any pressure to act immediately. Always think before acting, and instead talk to someone you trust.
8. Use secure and traceable transactions. Avoid paper checks.
9. Whenever possible, work with local businesses.
10. Be cautious about what you share on social media.

If You Suspect a Scam — Who to Call

Keep this page near your phone or computer

FIRST — IF YOU SENT MONEY OR GAVE INFORMATION

- Stop sending money immediately.
- Call your bank or credit card company **right away** — ask them to stop or reverse the transaction.
- Change passwords for any accounts that may have been exposed.
- It is **not your fault**. Don't stay silent out of embarrassment — reporting helps stop the scammers.

WHO TO CONTACT

AARP Fraud Watch Helpline

Free advice from trained specialists — call here FIRST if you're unsure

 **877-908-3360**

 aarp.org/fraudwatchnetwork

Monday–Friday, 8 a.m.–8 p.m. ET (you do not need to be an AARP member)

National Elder Fraud Hotline

U.S. Dept. of Justice hotline for people age 60+ — case managers help you report and find resources

 **833-372-8311 (833-FRAUD-11)**

 ovc.ojp.gov/program/stop-elder-fraud

Monday–Friday, 10 a.m.–6 p.m. ET

Federal Trade Commission (FTC)

Main federal agency for reporting scams, fraud, and bad business practices

 **877-382-4357 (877-FTC-HELP)**

 ReportFraud.ftc.gov

FBI — Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3)

Online reporting for any scam involving email, text, websites, or online payment

 IC3.gov

Better Business Bureau (BBB) Scam Tracker

Report online — also search to see if others reported the same scam

 BBB.org/scamtracker

Your Local Police (non-emergency)

File a report — important for insurance and for any chance of recovery

 San Mateo Police **local non-emergency number (650-522-7700)**

Use 911 only if you are in immediate danger

FOR SPECIFIC TYPES OF SCAMS

If the scam involves...	Also contact
Social Security	Social Security fraud hotline: 800-269-0271 — oig.ssa.gov
Medicare	1-800-MEDICARE (800-633-4227) — medicare.gov/fraud
IRS / taxes	Treasury Inspector General: 800-366-4484 — tigta.gov
Your bank or credit card	Call the number on the back of your card — do NOT use a number a caller gave you
Identity theft	IdentityTheft.gov (FTC) — guided recovery plan
Mail or package scam	U.S. Postal Inspection Service: 877-876-2455 — uspis.gov
Your cell phone or text	Forward suspicious texts to 7726 (SPAM)

When in doubt: hang up or disengage, slow down, and call someone you trust.
No legitimate government agency, bank, or company will ever demand payment by cash in person, gift card, or wire transfer.